waging nuclear war are among the most secret of state secrets (and therefore among the greatest prizes for gatherers of intelligence). Many aspects of the command and control of nuclear weapons in 1962 remain opaque, which inevitably hampers assessment of the risks.

If the US forces had attacked the missiles, there were several routes to retaliation from Cuba: a direct order from Moscow, a decision by General Pliyev, or conceivably, his subordinates (as when Major Anderson's U-2 was shot down). The nature of the retaliation would likely have been informed by whether the attack was selective or extensive and whether it presaged an invasion.

The possibility that some missiles might have escaped destruction cannot be completely ruled out. So, what of Soviet retaliation? Would the Presidium have risked US nuclear retaliation against the Soviet Union (and indeed directly on the Kremlin)? The question goes to the heart of the theory of nuclear deterrence. Certainly, the Soviet armed forces would have suffered many casualties in Cuba, running into thousands if an invasion had followed. Would Moscow have retaliated with nuclear weapons against the United States? Or Guantánamo? Or would nuclear retaliation have been aimed at Turkey (a concern that exercised members of ExComm). Or, as many in ExComm anticipated (and JFK expected), would the Soviet response have been to seize West Berlin?

It is certainly possible that the Presidium would have taken a hard-headed decision and written off its losses in Cuba. Yet, on the morning of 28 October 1962, when Khrushchev told the assembled Presidium it was necessary to 'retreat', he also said: 'If an attack is provoked, we have issued an order to inflict a retaliatory strike.'[66] Had he? No evidence has emerged of such an order. A more likely explanation of his statement is: 'He would say that wouldn't he?' In other words, Khrushchev needed to convince the Presidium that withdrawing the missiles in return for a no-invasion pledge was prudence, not weakness (and indeed successful). As he later put it: '[the] Caribbean Crisis represents a jewel of our foreign policy [which] achieved exceptional success for Cuba without a single shot.'[67] So, no sign of a wooden knife there, then.